A tiger did carry off a soldier on at least one occasion. On another, a leopard jumped out of a tree and mauled five sepoys. In an act of extraordinary bravery, Rennell grabbed a bayonet and thrust it into the beast's mouth. On yet another occasion, Rennell sustained deep sabre wounds while fighting off bandits. At thirty-five, Rennell returned to England and produced the famous *Bengal Atlas*. He was hailed as 'the Father of Indian Geography'.

Although it was the best that has been done thus far, Rennell's work had covered only a small part of the subcontinent. As British conquests expanded, the need for further surveys was felt. The task fell to acerbic genius William Lambton, who had had a long but unremarkable career in India till he was made the Superintendent of the Great Trigonometrical Survey of India. He got the job quite by chance. In 1798, he happened to be sailing from Calcutta to Madras on the same ship as a young colonel called Arthur Wellesley. He would go on to become famous as the Duke of Wellington and the victor at Waterloo, but in 1798 he was better known as the younger brother of the Governor General and was on his way to fight against Tipu Sultan of Mysore. He seems to have been impressed with Lambton and took him along for the expedition. Tipu Sultan was defeated and killed at the siege of Srirangapatnam. Lambton played his part with distinction. By consulting the stars he was able to avert a major disaster during a manoeuvre when British troops were unknowingly marching north into enemy lines rather than south to a defensible position. [5]

It was during the campaign that Lambton came up with the idea of doing a survey of India using triangulation. Basically, this requires three mutually visible points as corners of a triangle. If one knows the length of any of the sides and can measure the angles, the length of the other sides can be established by trigonometry. The newly determined sides can then each be used to establish a new triangle and so on. It is tedious work but provides very accurate measurements. Lambton had another motive beyond just creating an accurate map of India. Using this methodology, he wanted to also use the measurements to establish the exact shape and curvature of the earth. This was not just scientific curiosity; it was of vital importance to a